

Module 18 · Exam performance

# Exam performance: TCF Canada and TEF Canada

Task-by-task strategy, what examiners score, and a four-week plan for the final stretch.

## ● YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Know the format and timing of every section on both tests
- ✓ Apply a strategy for each listening, reading, writing and speaking task
- ✓ Understand what examiners assess in writing and speaking
- ✓ Follow a structured plan for the last four weeks

| Test                               | Tasks                                                | Length            | Strategy                                                                                |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TCF Canada<br>(60 min, 3 tasks)    | 1: a short message (invite, inform, ask)             | 60–120 words      | Answer every point in the prompt; correct register; greeting and sign-off.              |
|                                    | 2: an article, blog post or narrative for readers    | 120–150 words     | Narrate with passé composé + imparfait; describe; give your impression.                 |
|                                    | 3: compare two short documents and give your opinion | 120–180 words     | Part 1: summarise both views neutrally (40–60 words). Part 2: argue your view (80–120). |
| TEF Canada<br>(60 min, 2 sections) | A: continue a news story (fait divers)               | 80 words minimum  | Keep the style of a news article; logical events; past tenses.                          |
|                                    | B: a letter or post defending a point of view        | 200 words minimum | Four-part argument with examples; formal register; connectors.                          |

| Test                               | Task                                                      | Timing                            | Strategy                                                                        |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TCF Canada<br>(≈12 min, 3 tasks)   | 1: guided interview — talk about yourself                 | ~2 min, no preparation            | Family, work, hobbies, plans — with details and at least three tenses.          |
|                                    | 2: interaction — get information in an everyday situation | ~5 min 30 incl. 2 min preparation | Plan 8–10 varied questions; follow up on answers; polite openings and closings. |
|                                    | 3: express a point of view on a question                  | ~4 min 30, no preparation         | Position → reasons with examples → concession → conclusion. Keep talking.       |
| TEF Canada<br>(15 min, 2 sections) | A: obtain information (e.g. about an ad) by phone         | ~5 min                            | Ask many well-formed questions in the vous register.                            |
|                                    | B: present a document and convince a friend               | ~10 min                           | Summarise, give arguments, answer objections, use the conditional.              |

## ● KEY PHRASES

**Bonjour, je vous appelle au sujet de votre annonce.**  
Hello, I'm calling about your ad.

**Pardon, pourriez-vous répéter la question, s'il vous plaît ?**  
Sorry, could you repeat the question, please?

**C'est une question intéressante. Alors, à mon avis...**  
That's an interesting question. So, in my view...

**Je vais vous donner un exemple concret.**  
Let me give you a concrete example.

**Il est vrai que... mais d'un autre côté...**  
It's true that... but on the other hand...

**Pour résumer, je dirais que...**  
To sum up, I'd say that...

**Merci beaucoup pour votre temps. Bonne journée !**  
Thank you very much for your time. Have a good day!

## ● AVOID THESE MISTAKES

**X Answering the topic you prepared instead of the question asked** ✓ **Rephrase the question in your first sentence, then answer it**  
Task completion is scored first.

**X Stopping after 90 seconds in a 4-minute task** ✓ **Plan three reasons and examples — enough material for the full time**  
Fluency and development are assessed across the whole task.

**X Writing 250 words for a 120–150 task** ✓ **Stay within the range**  
Going far over can cost points and time.

**X Only simple present tense sentences** ✓ **Show range: past, future, conditional, relative clauses, one subjunctive**  
Grammatical range is part of the score.

**X Spending 5 minutes on one hard reading question** ✓ **Guess, flag, move on**  
Every question is worth the same; later ones may be easier for you.

**X Memorising a whole model essay** ✓ **Memorise flexible phrases and structures**  
Examiners spot memorised text that doesn't fit the prompt.

## ● TIP

Keep a personal checklist of your five most frequent errors (from your practice and mock-exam results) and proofread for exactly those. It's more effective than a general re-read.

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# Exam performance: TCF Canada and TEF Canada: the rules at a glance

## Lesson 18.1

### CHEAT CODE Listening, step by step

1

**Read the options first**  
predict: a price? a reason?

2

**Who, where, why?**  
in the first seconds

3

**Write numbers down**  
don't hold them in memory

4

**Watch the traps**  
repeated words,  
negations, the final  
decision

## Lesson 18.2

### CHEAT CODE Reading, step by step

1

**~90 s per question**  
they get harder — don't  
burn time early

2

**Question first**  
then scan the text

3

**What kind of document?**  
notice, ad, email, article

4

**Look for paraphrase**  
wrong answers copy the  
exact words

## Lesson 18.3

### CHEAT CODE

#### TCF Canada writing: 60 minutes, 3 tasks

60–120  
words

##### Task 1

A short  
message:  
invite, inform,  
ask

120–150  
words

##### Task 2

An article or  
story: narrate  
and describe

120–180  
words

##### Task 3

Compare two  
documents,  
give your  
view

## Lesson 18.4

### CHEAT CODE

#### TCF Canada speaking: about 12 minutes

~2 min

##### Task 1 · interview

Talk about  
yourself

2 min prep +  
3:30

##### Task 2 · interaction

Ask questions  
to get  
information

4:30, no  
prep

##### Task 3 · opinion

Give and  
defend a  
point of view

## Lesson 18.5

### CHEAT CODE The last four weeks



#### 4 weeks out

Every mock  
once. List your  
weakest  
section and  
top 5 errors.



#### 3 weeks out

Weakest  
section daily. A  
timed task  
every other  
day.



#### 2 weeks out

Recorded  
speaking  
simulations,  
single-play  
listening.



#### Final week

Light review,  
one last mock,  
sleep well.